The Gift of Prophecy

Purpose: *To show how God does everything in his power to guide us thru the gift of prophecy.*

Centred on: *Jesus Christ gives the right message at the right time.*

Introduction

Luke 10: 16… According to Jesus, if people ignored the preaching of John, James, Bartholomew, Thomas and Peter, who were they really ignoring? And likewise, if they in turn listened to these apostles, who were they really hearing?....Jesus and the Father.

So in essence, when God sends a prophet, it is as if he is speaking himself. It's important to listen to God's prophets.

Mark 6: 14-18… Notice how Herod relates the preaching and ministry of Jesus to his former experience with John the Baptist. This is clearly a combination of superstition and guilt, as Herod was responsible for the beheading of John due to his claim that it was unlawful for him to be committing adultery. (John's message didn't originate with him it came from God)

Luke 23: 8-9… Now Jesus came to save the lost, yet when Jesus is confronted with Herod whom is eager to ask him many things, Jesus stands silent. Why?

Jesus had already spoken through his prophet John and Herod was not interested. When God sends prophets to speak on his behalf, we need to listen to their messages of reproof and guidance. (Can you see that its imperative to listen to God thru his chosen messenger)

God sends humble men with no outward appearance to test the true nature of hearts. (e.g. The Exodus account Moses/Pharaoh)

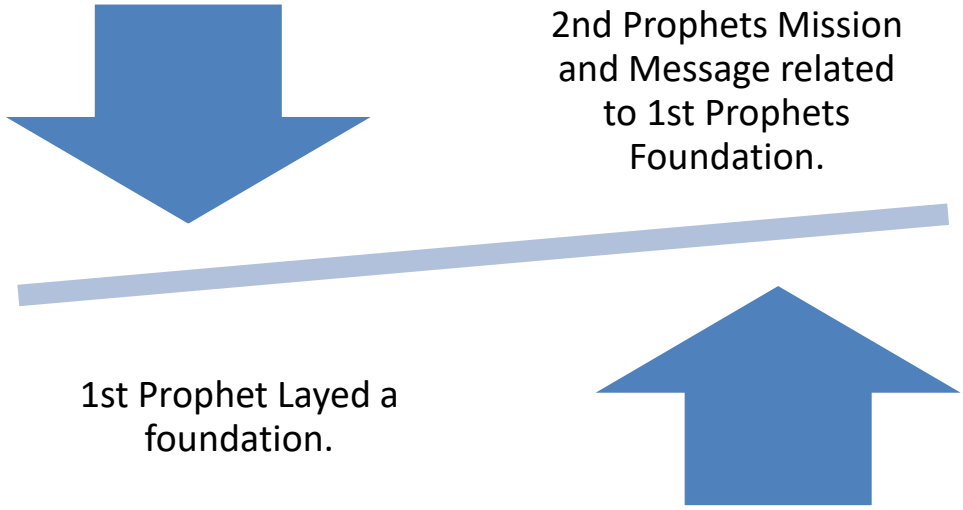
Amos 3: 7… God does *nothing* unless he reveals his secret to the prophets. (God's method to communicate to us is thru his prophets)

2 Chronicles 20: 20… Believe in God and you shall be established, believe in his prophets, and you shall prosper.

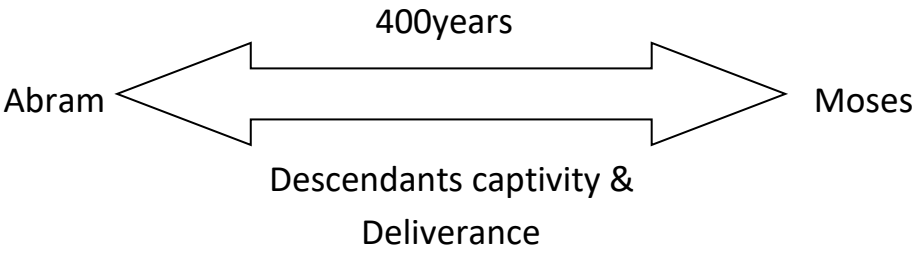
Malachi 3: 6…God is consistent.

Now we will take a look at the prophetic pattern established through the course of scriptures. We shall find a consistent pattern in which God initially establishes a time prophecy through a certain prophet, then near the end of the fulfilment of that time frame he raise up a second prophet. Whenever God raised up that second prophet, his/her message is a confirmation and establishment of the fulfilment of the initial prophet. **(Mission and Message relate to time prophecy)**

The Prophet Sandwich: (Let's look at several examples)

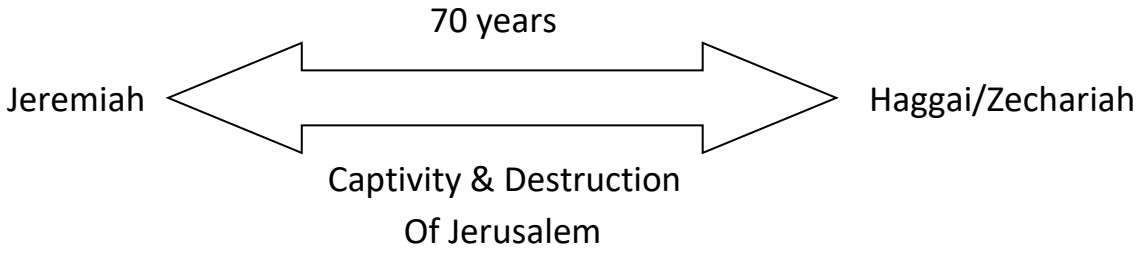


Genesis 15: 13-14…Here we have a prophet and a time prophecy. God is revealing his secrets to Abram.



Exodus 3: 7-10…Notice how Moses had a mission and a message that was the direct fulfilment of the prophet that God had sent in the past. So God had raised up a prophet (Moses), toward the end of the time prophecy given approx 400 years earlier (Abram).

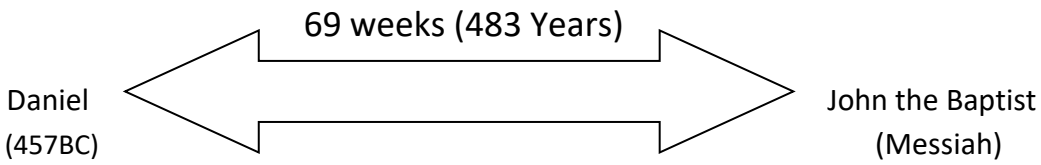
Jeremiah 29: 10…God speaking to his people through Jeremiah tells them that they are going to be living somewhere else for a period of seventy years (Babylon). But after seventy years, God states He will cause them to return home. Further details see **Jeremiah 25: 11-12.**



Ezra 1: 1-3…The spirit of King Cyrus was stirred up to fulfil the word of Jeremiah. The Babylonians came and destroyed Jerusalem, and then the Medes & Persians came and took over Babylon. So God was working through Cyrus to bring his people back home and rebuild their temple, then he raised up some prophets…

Ezra 5: 1-2…So God was working on Cyrus to fulfil his word and then he raises up a couple of prophets (Haggai & Zechariah). **They were helping the people of God to fulfil the word of God!**

Daniel 9: 25…Again a prophet and a time prophecy. From previous studies we know that the going forth of the command was in 457BC and therefore 483 years would lead us to AD27. So was there a prophet raised up toward the end of this timeline?



Luke 3: 1…In the fifteenth year of the reign of Tiberius Caesar.

Luke 3: 21…Jesus was baptized at this time.

Note: Many historians date the first reigned year of Tiberius Caesar as AD12-AD14

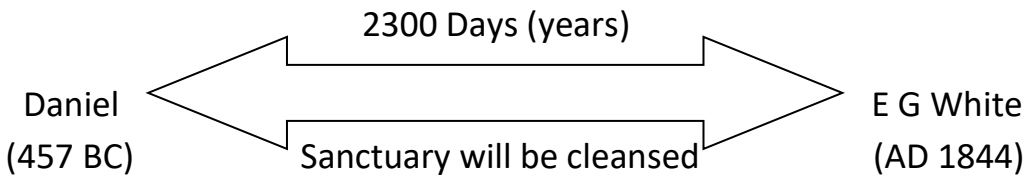
Mark 1: 1-4…John was sent to prepare the way of the Messiah.

Mark 1: 14-15… When Jesus says "the time is fulfilled," is it likely there was a time frame that had to be fulfilled? What time frame do you think Jesus was referring to? Daniel chapter 9 perhaps?

So the prophet that God raised up toward the completion of Daniels time frame was John the Baptist! God's time isn't always the right time for us as we think but that doesn't make it wrong – God thought it was the right time so it is.

Daniel 8: 14… A prophet stipulating a time prophecy, but at this point Daniel has been given no starting point. Daniel 8 is simply a review an enlargement of the previous chapter in which Daniel is witness to a horrific scene that involves Gods people and Gods truth being trampled to the ground. Gabriel is said to explain the vision to Daniel and begins with the statement *"the vision refers to the time of the end".* Gabriel is successful in explaining most of the issues depicting the world empires, however, when he begins to explain the 2300 days, Daniel is faint hearted and is unable to bear the completion of the explanation. It is not until the next chapter that Gabriel is sent back to pick up on where he left off.

Revelation 10… Depicts the magnificent disappointment of the early advent people. Many sincere bible students misapplied the sanctuary being cleansed as the second coming of Christ. In actual fact the sanctuary was in heaven. When going back to the scriptures to investigate their error, it was revealed that their time prophecy was accurate but not the event. The disappointment turned out to be one of the greatest bible revelations in all history. Seal up the book- **Daniel 8: 26; 12: 4.**



Critical thinking point: If we are to remain consistent with the prophetic pattern of the Bible, should we expect God to raise up a prophet at around the completion of the 2300 prophetic days?

Sociologists and modern historians say that the middle of the nineteenth century was labelled as the period of American enlightenment because there were so many people that emerged as prophets. Some of the more popular noted ones are as follows:

- Joseph Smith, Church of the latter day saints (first vision 1820).
- Andrew Jackson Davis, American Spiritualist Movement (1826-1910).
- Ellen Gould White, Seventh Day Adventist Church (1827-1915).

- Charles Taze Russel, Jehovah's Witness Church (1852-1916).
- Mary Baker Eddie, Christian Scientists (1821-1910).
- Edgar Casey, Affiliated with no particular group (1877-1945).

Note: to be consistent with the method that God has laid down throughout Bible history, in that the latter prophets mission and message **is consistent with that of the previous prophet**, there is only one of the above mentioned that is appropriate to apply to this equation.

Biblical tests for the authenticity of a true prophet:

Isaiah 8: 20…To the Law (writings of Moses), and to the Testimony (the testimony of the prophets concerning the Law of Moses). All prophets must be accountable and subject to all the previous patriarchs and prophets. God is clever enough to give his message through multiple people so there is a system of accountability.

"I recommend to you, dear reader, the Word of God as the rule of your faith and practice. By that Word we are to be judged. God has, in that Word, promised to give visions in the "last days"; not for a new rule of faith, but for the comfort of His people and to correct those who err from Bible truth".

White, Ellen Gould: Early Writings of Ellen G. Herald Publishing Association, 1882; 2002, S. 78

"The Lord desires you to study your Bibles. He has not given any additional light to take the place of His Word. This light is to bring confused minds to His Word, which, if eaten and digested, is as the lifeblood of the soul. Then good works will be seen as light shining in darkness".

White, Ellen Gould: Selected Messages, Book 3. Review and Herald Publishing Association, 1980; 2002, S. 28

"In public labour do not make prominent, and quote that which Sister White has written, as authority to sustain your positions. To do this will not increase faith in the testimonies. Bring your evidences, clear and plain, from the Word of God. "Thus saith the Lord" is the strongest testimony you can possibly present to the people. Let none be educated to look to Sister White, but to the mighty God, who gives instruction to Sister White.

Ellen G. White, Selected Messages, Book 3. Review and Herald Publishing Association, 1980; 2002, S. 28.

"In His Word, God has committed to men the knowledge necessary for salvation. The Holy Scriptures are to be accepted as an authoritative, infallible revelation of His will. They are the standard of character, the revealer of doctrines, and the test of experience. "Every scripture inspired of God is also profitable for teaching, for reproof, for correction, for instruction which is in righteousness: that the man of God may be complete, furnished completely unto every good work"

White, Ellen Gould: Ye Shall Receive Power. Review and Herald Publishing Association, 1995; 2002, S. 122.

The Spirit of Prophecy: "I Beheld," says the prophet Daniel, "till thrones were placed, and One that was ancient of days did sit. His raiment was white as snow, and the hair of his head like pure wool; his throne was fiery flames, and the wheels thereof burning fire. A fiery stream issued and came forth from before him; thousand thousands ministered unto him, and ten thousand times ten thousand stood before him; the Judgment was set, and the books were opened."

Thus was presented to the prophet's vision the great and solemn day when the characters and the lives of men should pass in review before the Judge of all the earth, and to every man should be rendered "according to his works." The Ancient of days is God the Father. Says the psalmist, "Before the mountains were brought forth, or ever thou hadst formed the earth and the world, even from everlasting to everlasting, thou art God." [PS. 90:2.] It is he, the source of all being, and the fountain of all law, that is to preside in the Judgment. And holy angels, as ministers and witnesses, in number "ten thousand times ten thousand, and thousands of thousands," attend this great tribunal.

"And, behold, one like the Son of man came with the clouds of heaven, and came to the Ancient of days, and they brought him near before him. And there was given him dominion, and glory, and a kingdom, that all people, nations, and languages, should serve him; his dominion is an everlasting dominion, which shall not pass away." The coming of Christ here described is not his second coming to the earth. He comes to the Ancient of days in Heaven to receive dominion, and glory, and a kingdom, which will be given him at the close of his work as a mediator. <u>It is this coming, and not his second advent to the earth, that was foretold in prophecy to take place at the termination of the 2300 days, in 1844</u>. Attended by heavenly angels, our great High Priest enters the holy of holies, and there appears in the presence of God, to engage in the last acts of his ministration in behalf of man,--to perform the work of investigative Judgment, and to make atonement for all who are shown to be entitled to its benefits.

The Great Controversy, Chapter XXVIII. - The Investigative Judgment.

Deuteronomy 13: 1-3…If a prophet leads you in a direction that is in direct opposition or disobedience to the moral commands of God, then this is a sign of a false prophet.

Jeremiah 28: 9…Accuracy.

Matthew 7: 15-17…The *product* of one's ministry is in itself is a test of a true prophet. What do they produce.

Appeal:

1 Thessalonians 5: 19-21…Would God tell us not to despise prophecies if there was no chance for us to despise prophecies? Test all things. (Amos 3:7 – otherwise your cutting off God)

Defend it:

Woman as prophets – Ex 15:20, Num 12:2, Jud 4:4 (Deborah), Luke 2:36, Acts 21:8,9

Outside of the Bible – Isaiah's books wouldn't have been in the prophetic writings of the day, i.e. the writings of every prophet weren't in the scriptures of the day. 1 Chronicles 29:29, 2 Chronicles 9:29, 1 Samuel 9:9

Some do not like the idea of prophets after the apostolic era:

Ephesians 4:7-13 - Prophets will be in the church till the end
1 Corinthians 1:6, 7 - Those w/ testimony of Christ come short in no gift
Matthew 24:24 - Why warn of false prophets if there would be no real ones
Joel 2:28, 32 (Acts 2:17-21) - People in the last days prophesy

Revelation 22:18:
Some people believe that this verse forbids us from accepting prophetic writings that were written after the Revelation.
Here are two problems with that idea.
First: John wrote his gospel after he wrote the book of Revelation. If we are not supposed to accept books written after the book of Revelation then we have to reject the gospel of John.
Second: Revelation 22:18 is a quote from Deuteronomy 4:2. If we understand Moses' statement the way these objectors understand Johns' we disqualify every writing other than those of Moses.

When John says not to add or take away he's warning against adding to or taking away from the messages of the book of Revelation.